

UNIT 7 : THE BRITISH LEFT : History & Ideology

Introduction :

= Labour Party

Historically : the Trade unions

Left = policies : nationalisation of industries, workers rights, incomes redistributions through the Welfare State, strong Welfare State

Tony Blair & new labour.

Birth of political parties in GB

Dividing line = blurred

More groups or factions, a question of support or not of the gov / King

One grp supporting the King and the other VS the decisions. No pol system.

The franchise was limited → no necessity of pol grp to gather a lot of people and to have a platform.

Two-party system developed.

End 17th : two groups =

- Whigs ⇒ liberals : originally applied to a group of Scottish rebels opposed to absolute monarchy and to the catholic emancipation. They were presbyterians (strong protestants) and wanted a moderate monarchy with a **strong parliament**. Were VS Charles I (a catholic) and James II (catholic, had to flee GB during 1688).
- Tories ⇒ conservatives (through Disraeli) : derogatory term to refer to Irish rebels outlaws who were catholics and criticised for being popish. In favour of a catholic and **strong monarch**.

The religious point disappeared.

1830s : Tories = pol party so the Whigs to.

Gladstone = Whigs (strongest enemy of Disraeli).

INDUSTRIAL REVOLUTION AND SOCIALIST MOVEMENTS

Emergence was eased by the 19th IR that gave birth to the proletariat who were eager of their living conditions → the beginning of trade unions (called socialist societies).

They fought for the workers and the enlargement of the franchise.

One great voting reform act in 1832 : double the number of voters but, you had to prove that you had a house → still connected to ownership.

Second great reform act 1867 led by Disraeli which enlarged the number of voters.

19th : socialist ideology developed through =/ mov :

- Chartism : charters and constitutions asking parliament to vote, act some electoral reforms. Chartist petition 1838 : 6 claims regarding electoral reforms.
⇒ 5 of the points were enacted

- Fabian Society : more intellectual → middle class intellectuals like authors (GB Shaw, Pygmalion & HG Wells, The Time machine) : pamphlets, wanted to negotiate that to rebel

1893 : Independent Labour Party : gathering of =/ trade unions. Led by Keir Hardie (1° working class MP thanks to the 1897 reform).

1900 : Labour Representation Committee : to promote the election in Parliament of working class men, to find a dynamics. Decided the creation of the Labour Party (1906) after a conference that gathered all the left groups.

FROM LABOUR PARTY TO NEW LABOUR

After the war : a constitution with one article = Clause IV → one long and complex sentence.
→ the labour party advocated for massive nationalisation : the State had to rule the economy of the country = "Common ownership".

Arg for the nationalisation :

- Can provide a greater public control
- Permit to establish fair pricing
- State should invest in infrastructure and innovations as well.

Clement Attlee's post-war gov : most of the production was nationalised : banks, railways..

1979 : Thatcher = privatisation

1960s : H. Gaitskell = Labour Party leader → first to consider the possibility to stop the nationalisation → If the labour party was losing grounds, because the public opinion became hostile. He proposed to amend Clause IV. Not followed so forgotten.

1990s : Tony Blair's modernisation :

- Created a "new party" = New Labour.
- Heading for centre-left
- Amended Clause IV.

→ more centrist ideas : limiting XXXX, a strong work ethic based on meritocracy, opening the markets (free because equality...)

Change in pol affiliations : the party was mostly financed by trade unions and socialist groups but with him, funding from private people / enterprises.

⇒ were criticised and seen as betrayal as traditional socialist values.

JEREMY CORBYN & KEIR STARMER

2010 & 2015 : Labour lost the elections (Cameron, Liz Truss, Sunak)

2015 : Jeremy Corbyn reenacted the question of nationalisation (was in favour). But he was not followed and Clause IV is still abolished.

→ created the Momentum Movement : trying to push the platform further to the left.

2016 : Brexit = impact on the pol landscape.

In pol parties : no uniform stance $\Rightarrow$ discordant.

Keir Stamer : « *You cannot move forward or grow the country or deliver change or win back the trust of those who have lost faith in politics if you're constantly focussed on the arguments of the past.* »

CONCLUSION

Next general election : Labour Party favourite

But difficulties to govern EX : socialist Party has collapsed in France.

Keir Starmer's leadership = two issues :

- The Government should be responsible for the day to day management of the country. But, they have a duty to limit the deficit.
- Decarbonisation and an available XXX.
-